CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



UNITED FORCE Opposition leaders march to the ED office on the Adani issue, Mar. 15

as a clean, incorruptible person," says a Congress Rajya Sabha MP. "Rahul targeted his personal integrity, Modi's biggest USP, in 2019 by connecting him to Anil Ambani and now to Gautam Adani. With his suit-boot jibe, he caused a great deal of discomfort to Modi in 2015. So, the message is loud and clear. They will go to any length if Modi is challenged."

Hence the digging up of an old case to embroil Rahul in. The case itself was filed on April 16, 2019, and Rahul Gandhi appeared in the court of the then chief judicial magistrate, Surat, A.N. Dave, on June 24, 2021, to record his statement in person. In March 2022, when the CJM rejected the complainant's request to summon Rahul again and insisted that arguments commence immediately, Purnesh Modi rushed to the high court to seek a stay on proceedings. This was granted on March 7, 2022. On February 16 this year, nine days after Rahul's fiery speech in the Lok Sabha attacking PM Modi for his alleged links with Adani, the complainant moved the high court again seeking vacation of the stay, pleading that "sufficient evidence has come on record of the trial court, and the pendency of the present matter delays the trial". Meanwhile, H.H. Varma took over as the new CJM, finished a speedy trial and sentenced Rahul by March 23. "They wanted him silenced so that he does not raise his voice against the prime minister on the Adani issue," says Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge.

A Binding Force?

Having been handed this 'opportunity', as some in the Congress perceive it, will Rahul's disqualification be the glue for that elusive Opposition unity? It has certainly brought together all the non-BJP parties, including the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress in West Bengal, the Arvind Kejriwal-led Aam Aadmi Party in Delhi and the K. Chandrashekar Rao-led Bharat Rashtra Samithi in Telangana. So far, the three chief ministers had maintained their distance from the Congress, skipping the Opposition meetings it convened. Unhappy with Rahul's style of leadership, they had been reluctant to ally with the Congress. But his disqualification led them all to condemn the BJP action as a death knell for democracy.

THE BJP IS LIKELY TO PICK ON RAHUL FOR NAMING THE PM **AMONG THE MODIS HE CALLED THIEVES** TO RALLY THE OBCs WHO HAVE STOOD BY THE PARTY FOR TWO LOK SABHA POLLS

Unless the higher courts come to his rescue, the disqualification will bar Rahul for eight years—two in jail and six after his release—from parliamentary membership. And since the prime minister of India has to be a member of either House, Rahul is also effectively out of contention for the post. Not only does it eliminate competition for Prime Minister Modi, the leaders of regional parties too can now fancy their chances of becoming prime minister in a coalition of Opposition parties.

For the moment, though, prominent leaders and allies such as Sharad Pawar of the Nationalist Congress Party, Akhilesh Yadav of the Samajwadi Party, Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin, his Chhattisgarh counterpart Hemant Soren and Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) leader Uddhav Thackeray (though he expressed his displeasure with Rahul's remark on Savarkar) have rallied behind the Congress on the issue. The sense of common purpose is also motivated by the realisation that they could be next. Most of them have been alleging that the BJP-led central government has been misusing central agencies such as the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), Enforcement Directorate (ED) and the Income Tax (IT) department to harass rivals. Fourteen Opposition parties, including the Congress, have already approached the Supreme Court over "arbitrary use" of the CBI and ED against its leaders.

However, the true test of Opposition unity will come in the electoral arena, where the Congress and other Opposition parties will have to be accommodative, both in terms of pre-poll seat-sharing and in drafting a common narrative. And this is where things can quickly come undone. Already Uddhav's party colleagues have declined to participate in a meeting convened by the Congress to chalk out a future strategy because they were offended by Rahul's comments on Veer Savarkar. Asked if he would apologise for the alleged defamation, Rahul had said in a press conference: "My name is not Savarkar, my name is Gandhi and Gandhi does